

## WHY INFORMED DECISIONS MATTER

Every action you take behind the wheel is a decision, from changing lanes to merging onto a highway. Making informed decisions means considering all the factors involved before acting. This leads to smoother, safer driving for yourself and others. Informed decisions can:

1. **Increase awareness.** Making informed decisions requires constant analysis of your surroundings. This improves your overall situational awareness.
2. **Promote responsible driving.** Understanding the consequences of your choices encourages responsible behavior. It also shows respect for other road users.
3. **Reduce crashes.** Anticipating potential problems will help you reduce the risk of collisions.

Informed decisions are impacted by your:

- Knowledge of traffic laws.
- Experience with safe driving practices.
- Capabilities based on age and brain development.

Teen drivers need to remember the part of their brain responsible for judgment and decision making is still developing. This means teens can be more prone to taking risks or miscalculating situations. All drivers need to prioritize safety-focused decisions over speed and social pressures. This is especially true for teens.

Older drivers want to be aware that physical and mental capabilities change with age. Older drivers can be more susceptible to serious injuries in vehicle crashes, but many remain safe and competent drivers well into their later years. Regardless of age or experience, all drivers must commit to staying focused and engaged every time they are behind the wheel.